

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

His ochre robes and saint-like demeanour make him look like one of the ubiquitous dera godmen in the Punjab countryside. But this baba stands apart. At his air-conditioned *kutiya* on the beautifully landscaped, leafy banks of the Kali Bein a clear-water rivulet flowing beside the historic gurudwara, where Guru Nanak

water WISE

★ **Sant Balbir Singh Seechewal, 45**

Project Cleaning up Kali Bein river

Can-do Icon Former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam for his inspiring ideas on building a grassroots-level environmental movement

The annual loss in productivity resulting from river pollution and other environmental damage is equivalent to about **4% of the GDP**



Dev stayed, in Sultanpur Lodhi town of Kapurthala district, Sant Balbir Singh Seechewal talks about the environmental message of the Sikh gurus, quoting the Guru Granth Sahib. "*Pawan Guru, Pani Pita, Mata Dhart Mahat*" (Air is guru, water is father, the great earth is mother), he intones before an impromptu gathering of followers who reverentially thrust wads of currency into his hands. The money is not for building a marble shrine—a preoccupation with most kar sewa babas in the state—but to buy ground-digging machinery for his ecological mission.

The sermon over, he hops into an improvised motor boat, steering groups of followers for a ride in the holy Bein where Guru Nanak is believed to have attained enlightenment while bathing. For the followers, it's an incredible experience. Till three years ago, the Bein was a dried-up drain, and reduced to a garbage dump with its historical and religious significance long forgotten. The rivulet now epitomises an ecological revolution led by Seechewal whose ground-breaking initiative has revived the 175-km long channel. Resurrecting the sacred rivulet has been a labour of love that made him widely known as the Beinwala baba. In fact, this college dropout has become the state's most-recognised eco-warrior, spearheading a unique campaign against the pollution of Punjab's rivers.

By combining his assiduously-cultivated self-help credo with the environmental essence of the gurbani, Seechewal has radically redefined the concept of kar sewa,

channeling public participation for ecologically important community development projects. While his mission has a groundswell of support from the common people, the authorities have also recognised his novel eco-initiatives. "Sant Seechewal has created a trail-blazing template to the people's power for the cause of the environment," says an appreciative Bikram Singh Majithia, minister for science, technology and environment.

Ever since he took over Nirmal Kutiyas, a locally-revered sect in Kapurthala district in 1988 as its youngest head, Seechewal has been known for the road less travelled. His initial community-oriented projects directed the kar sewa to building rural roads neglected by the administration. In 2003, he was struck by the state of the Bein. Devoid of river water at its origin because of the construction of a bundh three decades ago, it had long turned into a weed-choked, sewage-filled dump at many places or into a parched patch encroached all along its meandering route through Hoshiarpur and Kapurthala. Years of apathy had spelt death for the rivulet which has been a source of water for farmers in addition to recharging ground water.

Using the Bein's sacred status as a calling card of an awareness campaign, Seechewal mobilised the locals in a massive clean-up project that the Government could not have undertaken given its scale of expenditure. The most-talked environmental project of the state, it also earned profits from then President A.P.J. Abdul